

## Chapter 142-1

The cold winter wind rustled as the group stood at the entrance of the art museum, inadvertently forming quite a striking scene.

Liang Shi's response was neither servile nor overbearing.

Her face no longer held the world-weary look from before—at most, there was just a hint of indifference and barely perceptible disgust.

She simply disliked this person, that's all.

When speaking with Qin Lishuang, she didn't suppress her emotions, but she was much gentler than before.

Yet she wouldn't give anyone the impression that she was easy to bully.

Qin Lishuang was momentarily stunned by her words, and only after a moment did she recover her smile. "Here to see the exhibition?"

"What else?" Liang Shi retorted. "I couldn't possibly be here specifically waiting for the great painter Qin."

A slight edge showing through.

Qin Lishuang clicked her tongue and casually reached out to pat Liang Shi's shoulder, but Liang Shi took a step back to avoid it.

That hand hung suspended in the air, looking rather awkward.

"You've grown up." Qin Lishuang's fingers curled slightly in the air before she nonchalantly withdrew them, commenting with a light laugh: "More flavorful now."

Hearing this description, it didn't sound like she was evaluating a person at all.

And saying this right in front of Liang Shi's face meant she wasn't taking Liang Shi seriously.

Only those in positions of power would be so brazen when facing those beneath them.

But in terms of status and position, Qin Lishuang wasn't much higher than Liang Shi—they were about equal.

The only thing she had over Liang Shi was being a few years older.

Yet when Qin Lishuang looked at Liang Shi, she looked exactly like a master looking at a pet.

As long as the master beckoned, no matter where you ran off to, you, the pet, would have to come back.

Even facing Liang Shi's disgust and indifference, she still smiled with confidence, as if certain that Liang Shi couldn't resist.

Her current composure was merely a coat Liang Shi was wearing, while the real her was still a pitiful creature.

Liang Shi was actually a bit taller than her. She glanced at her lightly and said coldly: "I can't compare to you. Time doesn't seem to have been very kind to you lately."

She deliberately emphasized the formal "you,"<sup>1</sup> carrying a mocking tone.

Qin Lishuang wasn't annoyed. "Little Liang Shi, you're becoming more and more adorable."

Liang Shi let out a light scoff.

Qin Lishuang said: "I had already lost interest in you, but the way you are now has made me somewhat..."

She paused, her eyes roving over Liang Shi's body. "How about it? Would you like to... be my model again~?"

Qin Lishuang had a rather seductive appearance—a pair of fox-like eyes, wearing light purple colored contacts. Although she was a bit older than Liang Shi, she wasn't yet forty, and with how well she maintained herself, her skin was clear and translucent. So visually, it looked like Qin Lishuang was seducing Liang Shi.

Qin Lishuang's nails were very long, painted in a mix of gold and silver today. Catching Liang Shi off guard, she raised her hand and hooked Liang Shi's chin, her fingernail rubbing against Liang Shi's chin. "Right now, I'm very interes—"

Before she could finish the word "interested," Liang Shi bent her finger back.

Liang Shi bent her finger back to nearly a ninety-degree angle. In that instant, everyone present heard the sound of finger bones cracking—quite loudly too.

Qin Lishuang furrowed her brows, no longer as composed as before. "What are you doing?"

"That's what I should be asking you." Liang Shi said coldly: "What does Miss Qin think she's doing? Just because you're older means you can do whatever you want? In public like this, don't think that just because your reputation is already ruined you can act however you please. Do you even remember your surname? Does the Qin family know that Miss Qin conducts herself like this?"

In any case, Qin Lishuang's finger was in Liang Shi's grip, the fingertip bright red as if all the blood had been forced there.

Qin Lishuang tried to pull her hand free but couldn't match Liang Shi's strength.

"Mind your own business." Qin Lishuang retorted.

Liang Shi didn't listen and continued on her own: "Oh right, the Qin family does know. It's precisely because Old Master Qin dotes on Miss Qin that Miss Qin is so brazen. However... Old Master Qin seems to be on his last legs? Miss Qin should take it easy. Don't play with fire—when the time comes, you won't even know how you died."

Her brows and eyes were distant, her expression bland—she was simply stating facts.

But to Qin Lishuang's ears, it took on a different meaning. "Are you threatening me?"

"Not at all." Liang Shi said: "Advice."

Qin Lishuang wanted to say something more, but the person wearing the baseball cap beside her tugged at her. The voice was clear and crisp, urging: "Alright, let's go."

It wasn't the tone of someone trying to mediate—just impatience.

That person's way of speaking was quite blunt, far more direct than Liang Shi's earlier veiled barbs.

Judging by the voice, the other person wasn't that old either—definitely younger than Qin Lishuang, at least.

Yet Qin Lishuang didn't get angry when she heard her say that. After freezing in place for a moment, she answered with a hint of deference: "Understood."

When she looked at Liang Shi again, she had already put on a different demeanor. "Little Liang Shi, you really should go inside and take a look."

"Look at what?" Liang Shi asked.

Qin Lishuang sneered: "Look at what you did a few years ago."

"The you right now is like a cat." Qin Lishuang said: "I still prefer you with a bit of fire in you."

Liang Shi paused for a moment, then asked with genuine feeling: "What does what you like have to do with me?"

Liang Shi's voice was very cold: "I don't like you."

Qin Lishuang's expression changed.

But Liang Shi continued: "This narcissistic personality of yours—has it always been like this?"

The implication being—how long have you had this condition?

Qin Lishuang: "..."

After a moment, Qin Lishuang's eyes sparkled with scattered light. Far from being angry, there was even a hint of frivolous amusement in her smile. "Very good. You've piqued my interest once again."

"But what can be done?" Liang Shi applied force with her hand, bending her finger completely backward. Only after Qin Lishuang cried out in pain did she roughly fling her hand away. "I have absolutely no interest in you."

Qin Lishuang: "..."

"Auntie."<sup>2</sup> Liang Shi said: "One should have some self-awareness."

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## Footnotes:

<sup>1</sup> **Formal "you"** (您): In Chinese, "您" (nín) is the formal/polite form of "you," typically used to show respect to elders or those of higher status. However, when used sarcastically as Liang Shi does here, emphasizing it becomes a way of mocking someone—implying they're old while pretending to be respectful.

<sup>2</sup> **Auntie** (阿姨): While this can be a respectful term for older women, in this context Liang Shi is using it sarcastically to emphasize Qin Lishuang's age, essentially calling her old as a final jab.